The Dhāraṇī for Retaining the Noble Mahāpratisarā

Āryamahāpratisarādhāraṇī · Toh 944 · Derge Kangyur
འཕགས་མ་ས་སོར་འབད་མ་ཆེན་མ་གོཟང་བར་འགྲུབ་པའི་གཟུངས

This brief text, known in English as The Dhāraṇī by Which One Comes to Retain the Noble Mahāpratisarā, takes its name from its Tibetan colophon, which identifies it as a dhāraṇī for holding the noble great goddess Mahāpratisarā, called So sor 'brang ma chen mo in Tibetan. After a homage to the Three Jewels, it presents a single short mantra invoking Mahāpratisarā, the jewel-bearing, vajra-holding protectress, and promises that whoever retains it will thereby have retained this "queen of knowledge mantras" herself. Mahāpratisarā is best known as one of the five protective goddesses of the Pañcarakṣā tradition, and this condensed formula offers practitioners a compact means of connecting with her protective power. The work is Toh 944 in the Kangyur, where it belongs to the collection of dhāraṇī texts, the short incantations valued for protection and blessing.

Homage to the Three Jewels.

namaḥ smanta buddhānāṃ apratihata śāsanānāṃ oṃ maṇidhari vajriṇi mahāpratisare hūṃ hūṃ phaṭ phaṭ svāhā

By retaining this, one will have retained the noble queen of knowledge mantras, Mahāpratisarā.

This completes the dhāraṇī by which one comes to retain the noble Mahāpratisarā.

Translator's Notes

• The phrase rendered "queen of knowledge mantras" is "the noble one" in the feminine, followed by "queen of vidyā" (vidyārājñī). It is not the negated word for "knowledge" that means "ignorance," so the glossary sense "ignorance" does not apply. The verb "retain" translates the same Tibetan word that gives "dhāraṇī." The point is that holding this short dhāraṇī counts as holding Mahāpratisarā herself. "Mahāpratisarā" already contains "great" (mahā-, Tibetan chen mo), so "great" is not added separately.

Colophon

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Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.